

Political options in a democratic society-I

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THE forthcoming elections for the Jatiya Sangsad are a test for both the electorate and the contending parties. The electoral campaign, following the popular movement for democracy, has raised political issues of governance, national identity, people's rights. Aside from the populism of competing graffiti and slogans, voters are looking for answers to improve their quality of life, to end political instability and economic stagnation. Party manifestos have been published. From the hustings a range of issues can be identified for the local electorate. A candidate's commitment to specific policies will, to some extent, influence voting pattern.

We, as voters, need not only to assess the options offered by the candidates but to hold them to their commitment after the elections. To inform the political discourse a survey of 522 candidates in 100 constituencies in 52 districts was carried out by Gonotantrik Uddyog with the aim of clarifying the policy options available to the electorate. Below we discuss the more important constitutional and political issues which are being debated by different parties and candidates.

Candidates asked to rank major problems facing Bangladesh indicated different party priorities as follows: The Awami League (AL) recognised absence of democratic system, population growth, corruption as three high ranking problems; Communist Party of Bangladesh (CPB) and 5-Party Alliance, in addition to the

absence of a democratic system, identified class exploitation as the second major impediment. For Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) population growth and absence of a democratic system were ranked as the first two problems; Jatiya Party (JP) gave prominence to population growth and ignored absence of a democratic system or corruption as major problems. Jamaat-i-Islami Bangladesh (JIB) identified deviation from Islam as the most important problem.

In a democratic society the people's will should prevail. Political representatives must, therefore, take precedence in decision making over other institutions. The electoral campaign following the popular mass upsurge for democracy has raised political issues that must be settled.

The main obstacles to development were identified as misappropriation of national wealth and control by civil and military bureaucracy by most of the candidates. The debate on the constitutional system of government had entered the discourse well before the recent political movement. 63% of candidates in the interviewed sample favoured the parliamentary system. Where-as this included an overwhelming proportion of the AL, CPB, 5-Party Alliance, independent and other party candidates, almost 54% of Jamaat candidates also opted for the parliamentary system. Although the BNP has not yet committed itself to a change in the system of government, and the JP had strongly supported the presidential system, almost 23% of BNP and 25% of JP candidates interviewed gave their approval to the parliamentary system.

The debate on the separation between religion and state has always informed the democratic struggle in Bangladesh. In conformity with this 65% of the candidates did not support the introduction of Islam as a state religion. This included an overwhelming number from the AL, BNP, CPB, and 5-Party Alliance. In fact, it was only JP candidates (86%) who favoured Islam as a state religion. Their preference would indicate loyalty to their government's constitutional amendment. 50% of Jamaat candidates were

opposed to Islam as a state religion which may be explained by their opposition to Ershad's amendment and their stronger commitment to a theocratic State.

67% of all candidates felt that religion should be a matter of personal belief, and should not be subject to state intervention. Those holding an opposing view included 53% of JP and 83% of JIB candidates.

In a democratic society the people's will should prevail. Therefore political representatives must take precedence in decision making over the military and other non representative institutions. How do candidates seek to maintain the relationship between the military and political forces? While almost 3% of candidates did not see the need for a standing military, 72% favoured a different concept of defence through compulsory military training for all

citizens. The party with the largest proportion of candidates (55%) who wanted to invest in a professional military equipped with modern hardware was the JP.

However, a massive 91% of candidates did not want the military to have a role in civil administration. 83% of JP candidates were the highest proportion of political groups in favour of military interference in civil affairs.

On the issue of women's recruitment into the military except for 83% of JIB, 53% of all candidates were in favour.

Resolution of the ethnic issue is likely to be an early agenda for the next parliament. Therefore, candidates' opinions are crucial. 62% of candidates, except the JP, felt the Chakmas were oppressed by state bureaucracy. The latter's perception may result from the impression of 78% of JP candidates who saw the Hill Tracts movement as a separatist one. Majority of the candidates felt the need to recognise ethnic communities; a ban on appropriation of tribal land by non locals was recommended by 22% AL, 32% of 5-Party Alliance, 24% independents. Only 19% of all candidates were willing to concede autonomy to ethnic minorities.

Issues of current importance are Bangladesh's participation in the Gulf war and its dependence upon foreign aid. Over 86% of the candidates favoured Bangladesh's role as a diplomatic mediator of the crisis. In spite of Ershad's decision to send troops to Saudi Arabia, only 11% JP candidates expressed their support for participation in the Gulf War in support of the US-Saudi forces.

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There was a fair degree of uniformity on the need to reduce foreign aid. But 25% of JP expressed a need to increase aid. Most parties identified the undemocratic system and institutional weaknesses as the two main reasons for misuse of foreign aid. Interestingly, the JP and independents ranked the reasons in reverse giving lack of democracy significantly less emphasis. On the question of aid inflows, 49% each of both AL and BNP, 50% of 5-Party Alliance favoured a reduction. 25% of JP candidates wanted to

increase aid showing little concern for growing indebtedness. On the question of aid disbursement, most candidates gave priority to direct distribution to programmes for the poor. They also felt that distribution be controlled by the government through the upazila administration. There was general agreement that distribution should not be through the military. On disbursement of foreign aid, 45% of AL and 50% of 5-Party Alliance favoured strict government controls, whereas 41% of the former wanted to

maintain a balance between government controls and donor conditionality. An opposite view predominated amongst BNP, JIB and CPB of whose candidates 45%, 44% and 54% favoured the latter strategy.

How candidates view issues relating to women's rights and representation is important for those of us concerned with gender equity. Equality bet-

ween women and men is now an acceptable UN target, nevertheless 76% JIB, 30% JP, 15% BNP candidates did not concede the need for equal rights. As compared to this, 92% AL, 85% BNP, 81% CPB, 96% 5-Party Jote and 84% independents favoured equality of rights in all spheres.

94% of all candidates felt that women were victims of

oppression.. but 11% independents, 6% JIB and 8% JP did not agree. Most Parties attributed women's oppression to poverty. The 5-Party Alliance and the CPB considered the dominance of patriarchal mentality and poverty to be responsible for women's oppression. Departing from the general consensus the JIB ranked inefficiency of law enforcing agencies as a second

main cause for gender oppression.

Women's organisations have demanded that women's reserved seats should be filled through direct elections. Yet only 28% of all candidates favoured direct elections of women to the Sangsad, which included a majority of CPB, 5-Party Alliance and independent candidates. 37 preferred the existing system of nom-

ination by elected members of the Sangsad, which included 67% candidates from JP, 59% from AL, 49% from BNP, 38% JIB wanted to cancel reservation of seats.

An overwhelming number of candidates (87%) from all parties favoured equal wages for women and men. But 24% of JIB, 13% of JP and 11% of independents did not see the need for such equity.

Although candidates do not diverge from party positions on major issues, which makes it easier for the voters to make their choice on the ballot

paper, differences are noticeable in details. An apparent difference in candidates' responses on questions relating to policy and implementation suggest that political rhetoric may override political action, particularly on issues which demand a restructuring of power.

*This article is based on a survey conducted by Gonotantik Uddyog which is an informal network of persons, many of them involved with the women's movement, who worked together for the movement for democracy.